

Someone Left the Light On

He had not been back to his childhood home in fifteen years. He did not expect to find someone living there.

CEFR Level A2

Book 2 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: A terraced house in a northern English town. Owen's childhood home.

Genre: Mystery / Family Drama

Characters

- Owen — 38. Graphic designer. Lives in London. Returning north after his mother's death.
- Diane — 62. The woman living in the house. Sharp, careful, not easily startled.
- Helen — 35. Owen's sister. Lives locally. Practical and direct.
- Frank — The neighbour who remembers everything.

Owen had not driven this road in fifteen years. But his hands remembered it.

The motorway gave way to smaller roads, then smaller still, until he was driving through the town where he had grown up.

The terraced houses looked the same. The corner shop had changed its name. The library was still there.

He pulled up outside number fourteen, Clement Street, and turned off the engine.

There was a light on in the front room. That was strange. No one should be living there. His mother had died three weeks ago, and she had lived alone.

Owen sat in the car for a moment. Then he got out.

He walked to the front door and rang the bell.

He heard footsteps inside — slow, careful footsteps.

The door opened. A woman stood there. She was in her early sixties, with white hair and sharp grey eyes. She was wearing a cardigan and holding a mug.

'Yes?' she said.

Owen opened his mouth. He had not prepared for this.

'I — this is my mother's house,' he said.

The woman — whose name, it turned out, was Diane — did not look surprised.

She stepped back and said, 'You'd better come in.'

The hallway smelled the same as Owen remembered — old carpet and something floral. But the coats on the hook were different. A blue anorak. A beige raincoat.

'How long have you been here?' Owen asked.

'About six weeks,' Diane said. She led him into the kitchen.

'Your mother let me stay,' she said. 'She said I could. We had an arrangement.'

Diane made tea. Owen sat at the kitchen table — the same table he had sat at every morning for eighteen years.

'Your mother and I met at a day centre,' Diane said. 'About three months ago. I'd been having some difficulties — I was sleeping in my car.'

Owen looked at her. He tried not to show his surprise.

'She offered me the spare room,' Diane said. 'In exchange, I helped her. Shopping, cooking, a bit of company. She didn't like being alone.'

Owen was quiet. His mother had never told him she didn't like being alone.

Owen excused himself and went to the garden to call his sister.

'Did you know about this?' he asked when Helen answered.

'About Diane?' Helen said. 'Yes. Mum told me a few weeks before she died.'

'And you didn't tell me?' 'I thought she had. And then — I don't know. There were other things to deal with.'

Owen stood in the small garden. The apple tree his father had planted was still there.

'She's still in the house, Helen.' 'I know. I was going to talk to you about it this weekend.'

'What are we supposed to do?' 'That,' Helen said, 'is a good question.'

Owen went back inside. Diane was washing up the cups.

'Can I see the room?' Owen asked.

Diane dried her hands on a tea towel. 'Of course. It's still your house.'

The spare room had been his mother's sewing room. Now there was a single bed, a small wardrobe, a lamp, and a row of books.

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Owen returns to his childhood home and sees a light inside.

The books were organised — alphabetically, Owen noticed. By the window there was a notebook open on the sill.

'You can read it if you want,' Diane said from the doorway. 'It's just a journal. I write every morning.'

The next morning, Owen went to speak to Frank, the neighbour at number sixteen.

Frank was in his seventies and had lived on the street for forty years.

'Ah, Owen,' Frank said, as if fifteen years had been a weekend. 'Come in.'

'Did you know about the woman staying with Mum?' Owen asked.

'Diane,' Frank said. 'Nice woman. Came in September. Used to see her taking your mum to the shops.' He paused. 'Your mum seemed brighter after she arrived, if I'm honest.'

'Brighter?' Owen said.

Owen spent the morning going through his mother's things.

In the top drawer of the bedroom dresser, he found a photograph he had not seen before.

It showed his mother and Diane, sitting in the garden. His mother was laughing — really laughing, not just smiling politely.

Owen tried to remember the last time he had heard his mother laugh like that. He couldn't.

He put the photograph on the dresser and went downstairs.

Diane was in the kitchen making porridge.

'Did she tell you much about us?' Owen asked. 'About our family?'

'She talked about you both,' Diane said. 'You and your sister. She was proud of you.'

'But?' Owen said. He heard the hesitation.

Diane stirred her porridge. 'She worried about you. She thought you worked too much. She said she sometimes felt like she was bothering you when she called.'

Owen sat down. The kitchen clock ticked.

'I didn't know she felt that way,' he said.

'I think,' Diane said carefully, 'that she didn't want to be a burden.'

Owen looked at his hands.

Helen arrived at noon with sandwiches and a folder of paperwork.

The three of them sat at the kitchen table.

'The house goes to us equally,' Helen said. 'We're going to have to decide what to do with it.'

Owen looked at Diane. Diane looked at her hands.

'I know I need to find somewhere else,' Diane said. 'I'm not expecting anything. Your mother was very kind to me and I'm grateful. But I understand.'

Helen and Owen looked at each other.

'How long would you need?' Helen asked.

Helen called Owen from the garden while Diane was making coffee.

'We can't sell it immediately anyway,' Helen said.

'Probate takes months.'

'She was good for Mum,' Owen said.

'I know.' Helen was quiet. 'I was thinking — if she pays a small amount of rent, covers the utilities... it might actually work for a while. Until we decide.'

Owen looked through the kitchen window at Diane, who was doing the washing up again.

'I think Mum would have wanted that,' Owen said.

'So do I,' Helen said.

They told Diane over coffee.

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Owen discovers Diane, the woman who had been living with his mother.

Diane listened without interrupting. When they finished, she was quiet for a moment.

'I don't want to be charity,' she said.

'It's not charity,' Helen said firmly. 'You'd pay rent. Small, but real. And you'd keep the place looked after — you're clearly good at that.'

Diane looked at the kitchen. Then at the garden. Then at Owen.

'Your mother used to sit there in the afternoon,' she said, pointing to the chair by the window. 'I always made sure the cushion was right.'

Owen nodded. 'Stay,' he said. 'For now.'

Owen spent three days going through his mother's possessions.

Diane helped — quietly, practically. She knew where things were. She knew which teacups his mother had used every day and which were kept for visitors.

On the second day, Owen found a box of letters in the wardrobe.

They were his letters — from university, from his early twenties, before email.

His mother had kept every one. They were tied with ribbon and labelled in her handwriting: Owen's letters. He sat on the bedroom floor and read one. Then another. Then he stopped.

On his last afternoon, Owen sat in the garden with Diane.

It was cold but sunny. They had tea.

'What will you do?' Diane asked. 'After this.'

'Go back to London. Work.' Owen looked at the apple tree. 'Come back more often, I think.'

Diane nodded. 'She talked about you a lot in the last weeks. She said she wished she'd told you things more clearly.'

'What things?' 'That she was proud. That she missed you. That she didn't want you to worry about her but she also wanted you to know.'

Owen didn't say anything. He just watched the garden. Owen drove back to London on a Sunday morning. He stopped at the end of Clement Street and looked back at the house.

The curtains were open. There was a light on in the kitchen.

He thought about his mother sitting by the window in the afternoon. He thought about the cushion being kept right.

He thought: she was not alone at the end. She had someone. I didn't give her that — but she found it. He started the car and drove.

Three months later, Owen drove north again.

This time, he had called ahead. Diane had made a casserole.

Helen was there too, with her husband and their daughter.

They ate at the kitchen table — all four of them, plus Diane. It was loud and warm.

After dinner, Owen went to the garden alone. The apple tree had new buds.

He called his mother's number by mistake — he had not deleted it from his phone.

It rang twice. Then the voicemail answered. His mother's voice.

'Hello, you've reached Margaret. Please leave a message.'

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Going through the house, Owen learns more about his mother's hidden life.

He listened to it twice. Then he hung up and went inside.

voicemail sesli mesaj hung up kapattı (telefon) Her voice, still in his phone. He listens twice. Then he goes back inside.

After dinner, Diane told them she had found a part-time job — admin at a local GP surgery.

'It's only three days a week,' she said, 'but it's a start.'

'That's really good,' Helen said.

Diane looked at her hands. 'I've also been looking at a room. In a shared house. Near the town centre. It's affordable.'

'You don't have to rush,' Owen said.

'I know. But I should start planning.' She smiled. 'Your mother used to say — don't wait until something runs out. Prepare while you still have time.'

Owen went upstairs to look at the spare room before he left.

The books were still there — alphabetically organised. The journal was on the sill.

He looked around the room. The single bed. The lamp. The small wardrobe.

He thought about his mother offering this room to a stranger she had met at a day centre.

He thought: she was more generous than I knew. She was braver than I knew.

He turned off the lamp and went back downstairs.

Before he left, Owen took the photograph from the dresser — the one showing his mother and Diane laughing in the garden.

He showed it to Diane. 'Can I take a copy of this?'

Diane took out her phone and photographed it for him. He sent it to himself.

He looked at his mother's face in the photograph. That laugh.

'She was happy that afternoon,' Diane said. 'We'd been watching a silly programme on television and she couldn't stop laughing.'

'What programme?' Owen asked. Diane told him. He had never heard of it.

'I'll watch it,' he said.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story. They are given together so the reading pages stay like a real story book.

1. motorway	otoyol
2. terraced houses	sıra evler
3. pulled up	durdu (araç)
4. turned off the engine	motoru kapattı
5. lived alone	yalnız yaşıyordu
6. rang the bell	zili çaldı
7. footsteps	ayak sesleri
8. cardigan	hırka
9. sharp eyes	keskin gözler
10. prepared for	... için hazırlanmak
11. stepped back	geri çekildi
12. hallway	hol, koridor
13. floral	çiçeksi
14. anorak	anorak (yağmurluk)
15. arrangement	düzenleme, anlaşma
16. day centre	gündüz merkezi
17. difficulties	güçlükler
18. spare room	misafir odası
19. in exchange	karşılığında
20. company	arkadaşlık, sohbet
21. excused himself	izin istedi
22. a few weeks before	birkaç hafta önce
23. deal with	... ile ilgilenmek
24. supposed to	... gerekiyor
25. apple tree	elma ağacı
26. washing up	bulaşık yıkıyor
27. tea towel	mutfak bezi
28. sewing room	dikiş odası
29. wardrobe	dolap
30. organised	düzenlenmiş
31. alphabetically	alfabetik olarak
32. as if	sanki
33. paused	duraksadı
34. brighter	daha canlı, neşeli
35. if I'm honest	dürüst olmak gerekirse
36. used to	eskiden ... yapardı
37. dresser	şifonyer, dresuar
38. drawer	çekmece

39. politely	kibarca
40. porridge	yulaf lapası
41. laughing	gölüyor
42. proud of	... ile gurur duymak
43. hesitation	tereddüt
44. stirred	karıştırdı
45. bothering	rahatsız etmek
46. burden	yük
47. ticked	tık tık etti
48. folder	klasör
49. paperwork	evrak işleri
50. equally	eşit olarak
51. grateful	minnetttar
52. expecting	beklemek
53. legal	yasal
54. immediately	hemen
55. probate	vasiyetnameyi onaylama süreci
56. utilities	faturalar, giderler
57. rent	kira
58. works for a while	bir süre işe yarar
59. charity	hayır, sadaka
60. firmly	kararlılıkla
61. interrupting	sözünü kesmek
62. cushion	minder
63. looked after	bakılmış
64. pointing to	işaret ederek
65. possessions	eşyalar
66. practically	pratik olarak
67. ribbon	kurdele, şerit
68. labelled	etiketlenmiş
69. handwriting	el yazısı
70. tied with	... ile bağlanmış
71. last afternoon	son öğleden sonra
72. wished she'd told	söyleseydi keşke
73. clearly	açıkça
74. missed	özledi
75. worry about	... için endişelenmek
76. stopped at the end	sonunda durdu

77. curtains were open	perdeler açıldı
78. at the end	sonunda
79. kept right	düzgün tutulmuş
80. started the car	arabayı çalıştırdı
81. called ahead	önceden aradı
82. casserole	güveç
83. buds	tomurcuklar
84. by mistake	yanlışlıkla
85. admin	idari iş
86. affordable	uygun fiyatlı
87. shared house	paylaşımlı ev
88. runs out	tükeniyor
89. part-time	yarı zamanlı
90. generous	cömert
91. braver	daha cesur
92. turned off	kapattı
93. thought about	düşündü
94. stranger	yabancı
95. photographed it	fotoğrafladı
96. silly programme	saçma program
97. couldn't stop laughing	gülmekten duramıyordu
98. heard of	... hakkında duymuş
99. take a copy	bir kopya almak

After-Reading Activities

Page 20 — Clement Street

Owen drove away from Clement Street on a Sunday evening.

In his pocket, he had a photograph on his phone: his mother, laughing in the garden.

He had a new contact in his phone: Diane.

He had a plan to come back in six weeks.

He thought about the light he had seen in the front room when he first arrived.

Someone had left the light on.

His mother, probably — she had always left the front room light on in the evenings.

Or maybe Diane. It didn't matter.

The house was lit. Someone was in it. It was still a home.

Vocabulary Support

contact

kişi (telefon rehberinde)

lit

aydınlatılmış

in his pocket

cebinde

probably

muhtemelen

still a home

hâlâ bir ev

Still a home. Still lit. Still lived in. That is what matters.

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word with the correct meaning.

Word

Meaning

1. arrangement
- A. minnettär
2. burden
- B. düzenleme
3. grateful
- C. yük
4. possessions
- D. pratik olarak
5. practically
- E. eşyalar
6. generous
- F. cömert
7. probate
- G. vasiyetnameyi onaylama
8. hesitation
- H. tereddüt

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word from the box and write it in the blank.

arrangement — brighter — burden — charity — prepared — alone

1. Owen's mother had made an _____ with Diane — a room in exchange for help.
2. Frank said Owen's mother seemed _____ after Diane arrived.
3. Diane said she did not want to accept _____ — she wanted to pay rent.
4. His mother didn't want to be a _____ to her children.
5. Owen was not _____ to find someone living in his mother's house.
6. His mother had lived _____ after the children moved away.

Answer Key

True or False? Write T or F.

1. Owen has been back to the house many times in recent years. ____
2. Diane was staying in the house with Owen's mother's permission. ____
3. Helen did not know about Diane. ____
4. Frank says Owen's mother seemed happier after Diane arrived. ____
5. Owen finds his mother's letters tied with ribbon. ____
6. At the end, Diane has found a job and is planning to move. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. Why did Owen's mother let Diane stay?
8. What does Owen find in the top drawer of the dresser?
9. What does Diane tell Owen about his mother's feelings?
10. What do Owen and Helen decide to do about Diane?
11. What does Owen find when he goes through his mother's wardrobe?
12. What does Owen do by mistake three months later?
13. What job has Diane found?
14. What does Owen think when he looks at his mother's photograph?
15. What does the final image of the story mean?